

Chapter 68_2: Bathed in Fire

Everyone had just retreated a few steps when they saw the sky suddenly brighten. A fierce wind from nowhere broke through the dark clouds, and a beam of sunlight shone down from a hole in the dark clouds onto the ground, creating a stunning scene where heavy rain fell all around while only a beam of radiance fell upon the swamp.

The white bones transformed into thousands of thick steel needles under the blinding morning light, arrayed behind Chu Qingqiu. Even the nearby ocean was stirred, with towering waves rolling up in spectacular colors.

The woman who seemed to merge with the beam of light lightly pointed with her arm, and the thousands of white bones behind her shot out like arrows released from bowstrings, replacing the raindrops as they flew toward Li Zhao'an. Li Zhao'an gritted her teeth and waved demonic energy to resist, but how could she withstand the Waning Moon Formation? She was immediately pierced by countless steel needles, screaming in pain with tears of blood.

The pain instantly drove away the demonic energy. Li Zhao'an suddenly became clear-headed, fear making her teeth chatter. The fierce wind blew her to the ground, splashing her face with foul-smelling muddy water.

"No, no..." She was covered in blood, lying on the ground desperately reaching for her treasure sword, but the great wind suddenly stopped, and a mud-stained foot stepped on her hand.

The heavenly light faded, the wind and rain gradually ceased. The owner of that foot grabbed her chin, forcibly turning her face to meet a pair of extremely beautiful peach blossom eyes.

Those eyes were like peach blossom petals after wind and rain, still bearing dewdrops that hadn't been shaken off, beautiful enough to captivate souls, yet also chilling to the heart.

"Divine Venerable, Divine Venerable, I was bewitched, it wasn't me who did it..." Li Zhao'an shook her head repeatedly. Her body was riddled with wounds that hurt terribly, and she was so frightened that tears and snot covered her face.

Chu Qingqiu was a person who upheld righteousness. She herself had been consumed by demons, so she should forgive her. Li Zhao'an held onto a thread of hope.

However, that beautiful hand gripping her chin continued to apply force, so much force that Li Zhao'an heard the sound of her own bones cracking.

"Living people cannot become puppets. If you had no killing intent in your heart, demons could do nothing to you." Chu Qingqiu's voice sounded, as indifferent as if she were holding a stone.

Li Zhao'an held back tears, the teardrops nearly squeezing out of her eye sockets. She could no longer speak, only hearing that beautiful voice continue to whisper.

"I will not permit anyone to harm her life."

As soon as the words "her life" were spoken, Li Zhao'an heard the loudest crack yet. Something inside her body seemed to disappear, and so in extreme fear, her hands sank into the mud and her body slowly stiffened.

The others couldn't hear what Chu Qingqiu said, but they witnessed Li Zhao'an's death. The swampland fell into silence, the rain gradually lessened, and no one dared to speak.

Chu Qingqiu's body stood up. She retracted her white bones, her right hand clenching her clothing under the cover of her sleeve, yet she couldn't control the trembling.

Killing Li Zhao'an couldn't change anything. Her mind was completely empty at this moment, and her overextended immortal power also made her dizzy. If this formation had been easy as a snap of her fingers before, she now had only half her cultivation remaining.

What else could she do? Chu Qingqiu turned around step by step to face the crowd showing fear, feeling at a loss for the first time.

How else could she hold on?

As if troubles never come singly, at this moment thunder suddenly rumbled in the sky again. The dark clouds that had just been broken reformed, and the beam of light that could bring warmth disappeared once more.

Elder Pingyao frowned as she looked toward the horizon, seeing that at some point a masked figure stood among the rolling black clouds. His fluttering robes emitted black smoke like a chimney, the black smoke overlapping and merging with the dark clouds as if all the dense clouds in the sky were born from him.

The demonic aura around them couldn't be ignored. Her heart trembled, and she quickly gripped her magical artifact.

"This is a real demon!" Rong Jin said hoarsely. "Fuyi was right—it must be the one that broke into Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate!"

Several Eastern Courtyard disciples took up their magical artifacts, their hearts both fearful and curious. Hong Ying held his heavy sword, with a trace of excitement in his eyes: "We've been subduing demons and monsters for many years, mostly seeing demon beasts and demon creatures. This is the first time we've seen a truly powerful demon clan member."

"The mask..." Elder Pingyao stared wide-eyed. "This person is the demon who broke into Zhaoyao¹. This person is extremely powerful—everyone be careful!"

The wind howled, thunder roared but no raindrops fell. That black-robed figure slowly descended from the sky, his hoarse voice like an ancient corpse speaking: "Divine Venerable Chu Ling, it's been a long time. Do you like this great gift I sent you?"

Chu Qingqiu looked up at him, forcibly steadying her body, white bones gripped in her palm. Something flowed in the depths of her eyes, then was covered by the fierce wind.

"That stinking girl is dead. You're next." The man laughed with a "ke ke ke" sound. He suddenly raised the Emei thorn² in his hand, and several bolts of lightning struck down from the sky, converging in mid-air to form a blue blade.

Above Chu Qingqiu's head were crackling lightning and fierce winds. She raised her hand to resist, but even more lightning blades descended from the sky. However, this time the target wasn't her, but the crimson swamp beneath her feet.

Borrowing the powerful force of the heavens, they crashed thunderously onto the ground, shaking everyone so they couldn't stand steady. At this moment, someone shouted pointing ahead: "Look quickly, the tiger's den has collapsed!"

This was indeed true. The originally waterlogged swamp suddenly caved in under the power of lightning, extending outward from that crimson ground. Everyone hurriedly flew into mid-air. The great pit beneath their feet continued expanding, muddy water splashing everywhere. The scalding hot air buried deep underground gushed forth, making the surroundings feel like midsummer.

"Not good! He wants to release the vengeful spirits!" Elder Pingyao shouted sternly, hurriedly summoning immortal power to cover the great pit below, trying to block those vengeful spirits that had finally seen daylight.

Seeing this, the others also quickly used immortal power to form barriers, working together to block them. However, those vengeful spirits were crazy enough to charge together recklessly. The barriers were like giant bubbles in a fierce wind, swaying back and forth, in imminent danger.

Chu Qingqiu had no time to think further. She gritted her teeth and raised her tired arms, one hand bursting with white light to strengthen the barrier, the other controlling the white bones to rapidly enlarge, meeting the rolling thunder summoned by the man wielding his Emei thorn.

The man kept laughing heartily. Chu Qingqiu was exhausted, her vision becoming dizzy, and she actually spoke aloud the thoughts in her heart with all her strength.

"Ning Fuyi!"

So noisy, so hot. The raging fire all around, her hands and feet had already turned to ash, her internal organs had long since melted. How could the feeling of being burned bit by bit hurt so much? It hurt as if the sky was falling and the earth was sinking.

Who was she? Where was she? She was in such pain.

Was there anyone to save her? Her soul was constantly being torn apart by the fierce fire. Just when she thought she was about to dissipate, her soul would reunite again to continue this suffering.

Someone was calling "Ning Fuyi" beside her ear. Who was Ning Fuyi?

She stared ahead—though she had no eyes—glaring at the rolling fierce fire before her.

Was there anyone to save her? She made painful hissing sounds, though she had no mouth either.

But someone heard her cries. A human face appeared in the fierce fire. That face was very familiar, but she couldn't remember where she'd seen it.

That person's expression was very strange—extremely confused, extremely helpless, yet also mixed with some anger.

"You little brat, dying is one thing, but why drag me into it?" That person's voice carried a somewhat intoxicating charm as she angrily scolded.

"I'm sorry." Though she didn't know why the other was scolding her, she remembered someone had told her that people should admit their mistakes and change, so she tried hard to apologize with her soul.

That person was silent for a long while, then sighed quietly in the fire and suddenly spoke: "Someone is calling you."

"Do you still want to live?"

Footnotes:

¹ Zhaoyao (招摇) - Zhaoyao Mountain, another sect's territory that was previously mentioned as being infiltrated by demons

² Emei thorn (峨眉刺) - A type of weapon, traditionally a double-pointed stabbing weapon used in Chinese martial arts